SPE-229417-MS

Creating Future Ready Leaders

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This paper was prepared for presentation at the ADIPEC held in Abu Dhabi, UAE, 3 – 6 November 2025.

Abstract

The rapid evolution of the energy industry driven by advances in artificial intelligence, digital technology, and the ever-increasing demands of globalization, has fundamentally transformed what it means to be an effective leader. Leaders now are no longer only a technical expertise and operational know-how employees. Today's leaders must possess a set of skills that enable them to navigate the complexities of a connected, digital-first, and culturally diverse global workforce.

Several companies in the energy sector have recognized the urgent necessity of cultivating a new generation of leaders who are not only technically proficient but are also equipped with the unique competencies of AI Integration and Cultural Intelligence. These companies are acutely aware that leadership in the 21st century requires a blend of digital literacy, emotional agility, and global awareness, underpinned by ethical decision-making and a commitment to sustainability.

By embedding these critical elements into leadership Model which includes People, Sustainability, Profitability, Efficiency with the vital new pillars of artificial intelligence and cultural adaptability the companies are proactively shaping an agile and future-ready leadership pipeline. During my search I have identified several programs that supports this leadership framework such as Panel Operator Program, Youth Development Program, Knowledge Nexus, Culture master class, Talent Accelerator Program the Talent accelerator AI program. Each program is meticulously designed to nurture talent at every stage of their career journey ensuring a seamless progression from entry-level roles to senior leadership positions.

From hire to retire approach ensures continuous development for individuals and alignment of personal aspirations with organizational objectives. Through a blend of formal training, real work assignments, mentorship, and mobility cross different functions. Employees are empowered to cultivate leadership capabilities that exceed traditional boundaries. Emphasis is placed not only on fostering technical acumen and operational excellence but also on developing the cultural sensitivity and digital mindset necessary for thriving in a rapidly evolving industry.

This manuscript articulates both the theoretical underpinnings and the application of the leadership Model offering a comprehensive blueprint for developing resilient, agile, and visionary leaders. By sharing insights into the programs, philosophies, and practical experiences that shape its leadership culture.

Introduction

The petroleum sector has long been synonymous with innovation, risk management, and operational discipline. However in the 21st century the pace and breadth of transformation have accelerated dramatically. The meeting of digital technologies particularly Artificial Intelligence with increasing workforce diversity and remote collaboration has created an environment where traditional leadership models are no longer sufficient.

Recognizing that the future will be defined by leaders who are both digitally literate and culturally agile. The companies have re-imagined its leadership pipeline focusing on People, Sustainability, Profitability, and Efficiency with the vital new pillars of Artificial Intelligence Integration and Cultural Intelligence. This approach is actualized from hire to retire ensuring continuous development and alignment with both organizations goals and individual aspirations.

This manuscript serves not only as an exploration of the leadership Model but as a detailed account of how leadership development, supported by targeted programs, prepares the workforce for a lasting and meaningful impact on the global energy landscape.

The Evolution of Leadership in the Petroleum Industry

Progressive Leadership in the petroleum industry

Leadership philosophy in the petroleum industry has been deeply influenced by the values of each country. The focus on technical excellence and operational reliability laid the foundation for decades of growth and value creation. Yet, as the industry matured, energy companies recognized the need for a broader leadership vision that embraced innovation, collaboration, and adaptability.

Over the past decade, leadership development has evolved to address the realities of digitalization, environmental sustainability, and global collaboration. The integration of Artificial Intelligence and digital tools into core operations has created new opportunities, but also new challenges the most significant being the readiness of leaders to ethically and effectively manage these technologies, while also navigating increasingly complex cultural and geographical landscapes.

Meeting Contemporary Leadership Challenges

Leaders face a unique set of expectations that span technical, ethical, and interpersonal domains. Today's leaders must:

- Drive the adoption and optimization of Artificial Intelligence and digital technologies across complex projects from exploration and drilling to logistics and marketing.
- Lead culturally diverse teams create environments that foster inclusion, psychological safety, and high performance.
- Manage hybrid and remote teams sustaining engagement and accountability despite the challenges of distance.
- Ensure the responsible and ethical use of Artificial Intelligence addressing issues such as data privacy, algorithmic bias, and stakeholder trust.
- Navigate the volatility and uncertainty of global energy markets responding with agility and strategic foresight.

The leadership Model is the answer to these challenges, introducing Artificial Intelligence Integration and Cultural Intelligence as the new benchmarks of leadership excellence.

The leadership Model: a Blueprint for Leadership Development

The Expanded Leadership Model

Original leadership frameworks from the energy industry includes People, Sustainability, Profitability, and efficiency as the base of its leadership philosophy. Each pillar supports a holistic view of leadership:

- People: Investing in workforce engagement, continuous learning, and personal well-being.
- Sustainability: Integrating sustainability and environmental stewardship into daily operations and long-term strategy.
- Profitability: Driving sustainable value creation by optimizing resources, maximizing returns, and aligning financial performance with long-term strategic objectives.
- Efficiency: Streamlining operations and leveraging technology to achieve maximum output with minimal waste, efficiency underpins the pursuit of operational excellence and continuous improvement.

The addition of Artificial Intelligence Integration and Cultural Intelligence as the "+" dimensions respond to the reality that effective leadership now requires digital fluency and cross-cultural adaptability.

The Novel Addition: Artificial Intelligence Integration and Cultural Intelligence

- Artificial Intelligence Integration: leaders in the energy industry are now equipped not only to adapt to, but to champion the ongoing wave of AI-driven transformation sweeping across the energy sector. Their capability is further strengthened by access to advanced tools in the energy sector such as ENERGYai, Neuron 5 and Microsoft Co-Pilot, which empowers leaders to leverage artificial intelligence in daily decision-making, operational optimization, and innovation. The development of Artificial Intelligence competencies is a deliberate process, cultivated through several initiatives from the energy industry including the Talent Accelerator AI program and the UAE National Artificial Intelligence & Generative AI Program. These programs ensure that leaders are not only versed in the strategic application of AI, but also agile in responding to emerging digital opportunities and challenges. This expanded role demands an in-depth understanding of how artificial intelligence can be strategically leveraged to optimize processes, enhance safety protocols, and drive innovation throughout organizations. Leaders are expected to harness massive data streams for informed decision-making, balancing digital opportunities with careful management of cyber risk and ensuring responsible, ethical deployment of advanced technologies. This involves cultivating an organizational mindset that is both agile and resilient alert to the evolving digital landscape, yet as AI become further embedded into operational workflows, leaders must continuously evaluate, implement, and fine-tune AI-powered tools, anticipating not only efficiency gains but also the impacts on workforce roles, required skill sets, and long-term business sustainability. Supporting teams through this transition, fostering digital literacy, and maintaining stakeholder trust are now central to the leadership mandate.
- Cultural Intelligence: Leaders are called to navigate through different cultures, traditions, and professional norms. Cultural intelligence, therefore, becomes a crucial competency, enabling leaders to excel in environments that are increasingly diverse and interconnected. It empowers them to communicate with clarity and empathy across linguistic and cultural barriers to resolve conflicts constructively and to inspire engagement among multinational teams. Leaders are encouraged to cultivate an authentic leadership style that respects and celebrates diversity, adapts to local and international contexts, and builds relationships based on mutual understanding and trust. This enhanced cultural awareness not only drives internal cohesion and collaboration but also strengthens the companies capacity to form enduring partnerships and alliances worldwide.

By embedding AI integration and cultural intelligence into every phase of career development from onboarding to executive advancement the companies can ensure their workforce evolves in alignment with the rapidly changing demands of the industry. This comprehensive forward-looking approach guarantees that employees at all levels benefit from a robust, future-oriented leadership model supporting both individual growth and the collective success of the organization from hire to retire.

Bringing the leadership Model to Life: Programs from the energy industry

Below are examples from the energy industry which support the leadership model:

- Panel Operator Program: Focused on developing university graduate in addition to frontline and mid-level operators this immersive program utilizes AI-powered simulations and real-time analytics. Participants gain technical mastery while learning to integrate AI-driven monitoring and predictive maintenance into daily operations.
- Youth Development Program: Targeted at recent graduates and early-career professionals, this program offers exposure to core job activities, coaching and mentoring, digital literacy modules, and cross-functional experience.
- Knowledge Nexus: A platform for sharing expertise, experience, and innovations through engaging and insightful sessions led by Subject Matter Experts and On-The-Job Trainers including Three Sub-Streams:
    - Al Ma'aref – Discipline-specific knowledge sharing.
    - Knowledge Circle – Open discussions on key topics.
    - Geoscience Technical Knowledge Series – Specialized sessions focusing on geoscience innovations, exploration, and industry best practices.
- Culture master class: This dynamic course is crafted to deepen participants' understanding of Energy sector unique organizational culture and values. Through real-world case studies and dialogue with senior leaders, the Culture Master Class cultivates cultural intelligence, strengthens ethical decision-making, and fosters an inclusive environment where innovation and collaboration thrive.
- Talent Accelerator Program: A tailored pathway for individuals with significant leadership potential providing stretch assignments, global networking, and focused coaching. The program develops talented leaders to take on business management roles by developing their financial skills, commercial acumen and market insights
- Talent Accelerator AI Program: A forward-thinking program designed to cultivate the next generation of digital leaders. Building commitment to lifelong learning and growth, the program is tailored for individuals demonstrating significant leadership potential, equipping them with the skills and experiences needed to excel in an AI-driven energy sector.

These programs are strategically designed to support talent from hire to retire, fostering a culture of lifelong learning and progression.

AI Integration: enhancing Digital Leadership

The Role of AI Across in the energy sector

The adoption of artificial intelligence is transforming the way energy companies are running their operations. Starting from exploration, AI models analyze geological data to pinpoint drilling opportunities. For production optimization, advanced analytics predict equipment wear and enable preemptive interventions, reducing costly downtime. In downstream logistics and trading, AI refines supply chain forecasting and enhances transparency.

Programs such as the Talent Accelerator AI Program and Knowledge Nexus integrates these realities into their curricula, ensuring employees progress from digital literacy to digital mastery throughout their careers.

Building Digital Literacy and Mastery

Digital literacy includes:

- Foundational knowledge of AI, big data, and analytics.
- Critical thinking skills to interpret AI-generated recommendations and insights.
- Collaborative strategies for bridging technical and operational teams.
- Encouragement of a digital-first mindset championed by leadership and modeled throughout organizations.

The journey from digital literacy to mastery is reinforced through targeted training, Coaching and mentoring and involvement in different projects across the world.

Ethical AI and Responsible Technology Leadership

Ethics is at the heart of companies technology agenda. Leaders are trained to:

- Establish frameworks for transparent AI governance.
- Recognize and mitigate algorithmic biases especially in hiring, promotions, and safety protocols.
- Communicate openly with stakeholders about the impact and limits of digital transformation.
- Build systems for continuous monitoring and feedback ensuring ethical standards are not only set but lived throughout the organization.

Case study: OneTalent system

OneTalent system in the energy industry provides a strategic advantage by centralizing Human Capital processes and encouraging career mobility and holistic development. The system, supported by AI, utilizes skill management assessments conducted by all the company employees and approved by their line managers and assessors. Skills are divided into three main categories: technical, business and leadership skills. Following this comprehensive evaluation, a personalized development plan is set for each employee, tailored to support their growth and align with their career aspirations and mobility opportunities. The skills assessment is leveraged to identify individual strengths and development needs, guiding targeted learning and career pathways. This data-driven approach empowers leaders and employees alike to make informed decisions supported by AI analysis, ensuring the continuous growth of a resilient, diverse, and future-ready workforce. OneTalent holistic platform is key to sustaining the energy industry leadership and organizational excellence.

Developing the Next Generation of Digital Leaders

Development of digital leadership is a journey, not a destination:

- Continuous learning through programs such as Knowledge Nexus and Talent Accelerator AI including advanced AI modules and case studies.
- Executive mentoring and coaching in the Talent Accelerator program.
- Project-based assignments that embed digital transformation and change management into daily practice.

The result is a cohort of leaders ready to drive innovation and uphold the highest standards of ethical, tech-forward leadership.

Cultural Intelligence: leading multiculture task force

Embracing Multicultural Workforce

It is common practice within the energy industry to form multinational teams, bringing together expertise and perspectives from diverse backgrounds. This diversity is a strategic asset, fueling creativity, resilience, and innovation. However it also requires leaders to skillfully bridge cultural divides, foster unity, and build a shared sense of purpose.

Developing Cultural at Every Level

Cultural Intelligence is not an isolated skill but a fundamental leadership requirement, developed through:

- Formal learning modules on cross-cultural communication, negotiation, and global leadership.
- Assignments in multidisciplinary, multinational teams with international companies.
- Mentorship programs fostering dialogue between employees of varied backgrounds.
- Ongoing knowledge-sharing and peer learning.

Case study; Culture master class and Knowledge Nexus: Sustaining Energy industry Cultural through Continuous Learning

Both the Culture master class and Knowledge Nexus Programs reinforce Energy industry Cultural by:

- Making cross-cultural learning accessible and ongoing.
- Facilitating collaboration across business units, geographies, and professional backgrounds.
- Offering resources and coaching to address specific leadership and cultural challenges.

These programs ensure that Energy industry Cultural is maintained and developed throughout the employee lifecycle.

Hybrid Work and Digital Literacy

The Hybrid Work Paradigm

The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated the adoption of hybrid and remote work models. Energy companies responded by equipping leaders with the tools and training needed to:

- Foster team cohesion and engagement across virtual platforms.
- Utilize AI-powered collaboration and knowledge-sharing tools to enhance productivity.
- Maintain culture of innovation and inclusion regardless of physical location.

Technology as a Driver for Inclusive Leadership

Energy companies approach uses digital platforms, AI-driven translation, and shared learning portals to:

- Ensure transparent and inclusive decision-making.
- Promote the exchange of ideas and best practices across organizations.

- Recognize and celebrate achievements reinforcing a sense of belonging and purpose.

Case Study: Monitoring Bias and Ensuring Fairness in AI Systems in the Energy industry
Energy industry companies are vigilant about the risks of bias in digital systems. As Energy industry companies advances its vision to become the world's most AI-enabled companies, ethical AI governance has become a cornerstone of its digital transformation. The companies has adopted a multi-layered approach to ensure fairness and mitigate bias in AI systems, particularly those used in decision-making, safety, and talent development.

1. Ethical Framework and Governance
   Internal framework that outlines core principles for fairness and non-discrimination:
   - Bias Recognition and Mitigation: AI systems must be designed to identify and reduce biases stopping from skewed data or algorithmic tendencies.
   - Human-AI Comparison: Deviations between AI-driven decisions and human-only decisions are measured to detect potential unfairness.
   - Stakeholder Awareness: Users are trained to report concerns about bias to Ethics and Compliance teams

   This framework ensures that AI systems respect individual dignity and prevent marginalization based on inherent or acquired characteristics.
2. Training and Awareness
   Employees attending programs such as the National Artificial Intelligence & Generative AI Program are educated on how to avoid bias and ensure fairness through structured modules:
   - Bias, Fairness & Responsible AI: This module explores how bias affects outcomes and how to build inclusive systems.
   - AI Ethics, Risks & Governance: Emphasizes the need for responsible deployment and oversight

These programs foster a culture of ethical awareness and equip employees with tools to critically assess AI systems.

Building Trust: Communication and Transparency in Automated Environments
Trust is foundational to high performance. Energy companies leaders are trained to:

- Communicate clearly and regularly about the use of AI and digital platforms.
- Solicit and act upon employee feedback supporting a culture of continuous improvement.
- Model ethical conduct and transparency at every level.

By embedding trust and openness companies create a resilient motivated team.

Implementation Roadmap: Institutionalizing the ledership Model

Assessing Readiness and Customizing Interventions
Prior to launching new programs, Companies undertakes comprehensive readiness assessments, evaluating digital maturity, cultural diversity, and leadership competency gaps. These insights guide the customization and continual evolution of all programs.

Integrating the Employee Lifecycle: From Hire to Retire

Programs are strategically integrated:

- Panel Operator Program: Builds technical capability at the front lines, forming the foundation for further development.
- Youth Development Program: Accelerates early-career learning, exposure, and networking.
- Knowledge Nexus: Provides all employees with access to up-to-date resources, best practices, and peer forums throughout their tenure.
- Culture master class: empowers employees to embrace values, fostering collaboration, inclusion, and a shared sense of purpose across all levels of the organization.
- Talent Accelerator Program: Bridges technical and strategic leadership, ensuring leaders are equipped with the right financial skills and commercial acumen
- Talent Accelerator AI Program: Equips engineers with practical AI skills, combining hands-on training, real-world project experience, and exposure to emerging digital tools ensuring they are prepared to drive innovation and leverage AI across operations.

Overcoming Resistance and Aligning the Organization

Energy companies addresses challenges of change management and alignment by:

- Communicating the long-term vision and benefits of leadership programs.
- Offering recognition and incentives for engagement and achievement.
- Continually evaluating program outcomes and refining approaches based on data and feedback.

Measuring Progress and Impact

Progress is tracked through:

- Rates of digital upskilling and AI tool adoption across business units.
- Metrics on diversity, inclusion, and employee engagement.
- Retention, promotion, and leadership pipeline strength.
- Operational improvements and innovation outputs.

For example below are stats of Energy company progress in the above-mentioned elements:

Category	Key Metrics & Statistics
Digital Upskilling & AI Tool Adoption	• 85% of processes are now automated with intelligent tools providing advanced analytics for decision-making • AI-powered tools are used to analyse complex data, automate tasks, and personalize experiences across business units • OneTalent platform integrates 16 talent processes into a unified AI-driven system
Diversity, Inclusion & Employee Engagement	• 82% employee engagement score in the 2024 survey • Surveys conducted in Arabic, English, and Malayalam to ensure inclusivity • 93% satisfaction with succession transparency and inclusion
Retention, Promotion & Leadership Pipeline	• 95% of line managers accessed the system and nominated successors • 88% found the e-Talent Card useful for nominations • 94% agreed that transparency motivates talent development

Category	Key Metrics & Statistics
Operational Improvements & Innovation Outputs	• Skills assessment and Talent Marketplace initiatives are driving skill-based growth • Performance analytics used to profile high performers and guide career development • AI-driven career paths and predictive learning journeys implemented via OneTalent system

Below diagram explains the road map of the leadership Model

Section	Focus Area	Details
	Readiness Evaluation	Digital maturity, cultural diversity, leadership competency gaps
6.1 Assessing Readiness and Customizing Interventions	Program Customization	Tailored interventions based on assessment insights
6.2 Integrating the Employee Lifecycle: From Hire to Retire	Panel Operator Program	Builds frontline technical capability
	Youth Development Program	Accelerates early-career learning and networking
	Knowledge Nexus	Access to resources, best practices, and peer forums
	Culture Master Class	Promotes values, collaboration, and inclusion
	Talent Accelerator Program	Bridges technical and strategic leadership with financial acumen
	Talent Accelerator AI Program	Hands-on AI training and exposure to digital tools
6.3 Overcoming Resistance and Aligning the Organization	Change Management	Communicates long-term vision and benefits
	Engagement Strategies	Recognition, incentives, and executive role modeling
	Continuous Improvement	Data-driven program refinement
6.4 Measuring Progress and Impact	Key Metrics	Digital upskilling, AI adoption, diversity, engagement
	Talent Outcomes	Retention, promotion, leadership pipeline strength
	Operational Impact	Innovation outputs and performance improvements

Recommendations and Future Directions

Strengthening the Leadership Model

To further the success of the Model, companies should:

- Deepen the integration of AI and cultural intelligence into all curricula and programs.
- Expand partnerships for global knowledge exchange and benchmarking.
- Continuously adapt leadership models to anticipate and meet future industry trends.

Areas for Further Study

Ongoing research priorities include:

- Long-term impact studies of integrated leadership development.

- Exploration of AI and Culture effects on safety, sustainability, and well-being.
- Development of new assessment tools for digital and cultural competencies.

Conclusion

The manuscript details energy companies comprehensive approach to leadership development emphasizing robust collaboration with a diverse array of partners including universities, industry bodies, and specialized training providers. Together, these collaborations are instrumental in designing applied learning experiences that are immediately relevant to the industry's evolving landscape. Through these partnerships energy companies encourage ongoing research not just into digital and cultural leadership but also into the factors that drive innovation, adaptability, and resilience across organizations. By focusing on fostering career mobility and enabling sector-wide talent development, Companies ensures that talent is continuously cultivated and supported throughout all levels of the organization.

Key research priorities highlighted in the manuscript include conducting long-term impact studies that examine the efficacy of integrated leadership development efforts. There is an emphasis on exploring the intersection of AI and organizational cultures specifically, how these elements influence critical outcomes such as safety performance, sustainability initiatives, and the overall well-being of employees. Additionally, the development and refinement of new assessment tools are ongoing, with the goal of more accurately evaluating digital fluency and cultural competencies in a rapidly changing technological environment.

Central to the manuscript is the assertion that integrating AI into leadership development is not just an enhancement but a necessity for future-ready organizations. AI technologies provide deep insights and data-driven guidance, enabling tailored learning experiences and more sophisticated methods of tracking progression and measuring impact. Through the strategic embedding of AI into training programs, assessment processes, and even day-to-day decision-making, leaders are better prepared to navigate uncertainty, respond to disruption, and drive continuous innovation.

Ultimately, the expanded leadership Model represents a paradigm shift in leadership development. By weaving AI and cultural awareness into every aspect of the employee journey from initial onboarding to long-term career progression Energy companies are building a workforce equipped for the challenges and opportunities of a dynamic, globalized future. The manuscript concludes by underscoring that this journey is marked by a commitment to lifelong learning, adaptability, and a culture of innovation.